

Orioles' Weaver was rare minor bird 25 years ago

From a book of sports quotes: Dizzy Dean was catching flak for not knowing the King's English.

"Sure I know the King's English," Diz replied. "I know that the queen's English, too."

ORIOLES' TOUGH COOKIE: If Baltimore and Pittsburgh both wind up in the World Series, Andy Cohen might be in a dilemma deciding who to root for. El Paso's "Mr. Baseball" managed both Earl Weaver, the Orioles' manager, and Chuck Tanner, Pirate skipper in the minors.

One of Cohen's favorite stories about the Earl of Baltimore was when he managed Weaver at Denver, then a Class A affiliate of Pittsburgh's, in 1954. Even then, Weaver had the do-anything-to-win feistiness American League umpires know and loathe so much.

In one game, Weaver was leading off second base when a hard smash was hit right at him. Instead of moving, Weaver stayed right there and stuck out his hand, hoping to obstruct the short-

stop's vision of the ball.

But the ball hit Weaver in the hand — and stuck there. Weaver was out, his guile having backfired.

When he returned to the dugout, Cohen remembers telling him: "That was the greatest play you've made this year, kid. Unfortunately, it was against us."

After the season, Pirate boss Branch Rickey asked Cohen which second baseman he wanted to take with him the next year to AA New Orleans: Weaver or a prospect who had been at Williamsport. Cohen stuck with Weaver. "That's how crazy I was about him."

The player at Williamsport was Bill Mazeroski, who became, of course, one of the Pirates' stars at second base. Mr. Rickey didn't exactly like Cohen's judgment.

"I wasn't sorry I took Weaver," Cohen recalls. "He did a lot for me."

THE SHARK HAS PRETTY TEETH: Jerry Tarkanian, who spoke to the Oklahoma Coaches Association clinic the day after UTEP's Don Haskins was the fea-



Vince Langford
Times Sports Writer

tured speaker, says that he turned down the Los Angeles Laker coaching job because he wants to win his case against the NCAA.

Tark the Shark believes he will win a decision on the case in the next few weeks and that's why he's staying at Nevada-Las Vegas instead of heading to pro basketball.

"I wanted that job so bad," Tarkanian told a Tulsa newspaper. "They offered me the best contract in the history of the NBA. But my attorney and my wife — who is more into the NCAA thing than I am — said if I went to the pros, the six years we have spent building the case against the NCAA would go down the drain. They convinced me I had to stay."

That's bad news for the rest of the West-

ern Athletic Conference. Brigham Young, with five starters back, should be the overwhelming favorite to win the WAC basketball crown next season, and when UNLV becomes eligible in 1980-81, the Rebels might run away with the crown after Tarkanian's past two recruiting harvests.

IS THERE A DOCTOR J IN THE HOUSE: The injury bug ravaging the majors hit the Salt Lake City team this season like locusts. Ex-Diablos on the wounded list include ("Dr.") Jay Peters (broken leg), Bill Ewing (sent home following shoulder surgery), Stan Cliburn (broken wrist) and Bob Slater (rib injury).

Why the increase in injuries this season? "We've wondered endlessly about it," Mike Port, California's player-personnel director said last week in a visit to El Paso. "Some people that have been in baseball much longer than I have have speculated that over the last 10, 15 or 20 years players' activities in the off-season have changed. Players used to work on

ranches or farms in the off-season and be involved in some form of physical activity. There might be something to that."

SHORT SHOTS: The NCAA asked every college football player in a pre-season form of questions: "Who would you like to be if you could be anyone in the world and why?" Texas linebacker Lance Taylor, the ex-El Paso Coronado star, replied: "Burt Reynolds, 'cause he's my hero." The choice of his teammate, all-America tackle candidate Steve McMichael, was "Hugh Hefner, for the simple fact that he's got everything I want."

The NCAA also wanted the players to "describe your most embarrassing moment, in or out of sports." "Embarrassing?" responded Craig Groendyk, a senior at Hope College. "Picture this. You're just about ready to leave the dermatologist's office when he opens the door and shouts across the waiting room (filled to capacity with 15 people) 'Craig, if your jock itch doesn't clear up in two weeks, make another appointment.' That's what I call tact."